



# Perception and Individual Decision Making

Week 6 | Organizational Behavior and Quality

Official chapter focus: perception, attribution, decision biases, ethics, creativity, and decision quality.

**Quality lens: Better perception and evidence-based decisions → more reliable quality behavior**

**Core idea: perception frames the problem; judgment shapes the decision; evidence protects quality**

**Perception**

**Biases**

**Decision quality**

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Robbins & Judge, Updated 18th Global Edition, Chapter 6

Keep the session focused on concepts with direct OB and quality-management value.

## By the end of this session, students can:

1. Define perception and explain what shapes it.
2. Use attribution theory to judge behavior.
3. Identify common perceptual shortcuts and errors.
4. Explain the link between perception and decision making.
5. Contrast rational decision making, bounded rationality, and intuition.
6. Apply ethics and creativity to quality decisions.

Percepti  
on

Attributi  
on

Shortcut  
s

Rationali  
ty

Biases

Ethics

Creativit  
y

## Session logic

What do people notice?

How do they explain behavior?

How do shortcuts and biases distort judgment?

How can quality decisions be improved?

## Practical focus

complaint handling, audit evidence, employee evaluation, root-cause analysis, and corrective action decisions

Chapter 6 begins from the idea that behavior follows perceived reality.

## Case idea

A student submits an assignment late. The instructor thinks the student is careless. The student says the internet was disconnected. Other students think the instructor is unfair.

## Discussion

- What did each person perceive?
- Which information is missing?
- Which bias may affect judgment?
- What would a fair evidence-based decision require?

## Key message

**People act on how they interpret events, not only on the event itself.**

Quality connection: fair quality decisions require evidence before judgment.

Use the official definition and connect it to workplace judgment.

## Perception

**The process by which individuals organize and interpret sensory impressions to give meaning to their environment.**

## Quality caution

**Perceived reality can differ from objective reality; therefore, judgment should be checked against evidence.**

**Objective event**



**Interpretation**



**Behavior**

Teaching point: observation is not the same as interpretation.

Perception is shaped by the perceiver, target, and situation.

## Perceiver

**Attitudes**  
**Motives**  
**Interests**  
**Experience**  
**Expectations**

## Target

**Novelty**  
**Motion**  
**Sounds**  
**Size**  
**Proximity / similarity**

## Situation

**Time**  
**Work setting**  
**Social setting**

**Perception = what the observer brings + what the target displays + where the event occurs.**

Quality use: before judging an incident, check the observer's expectations, the visible target features, and the situational context.

The same quality incident can produce different judgments.

## Quality incident

A customer reports long waiting time. The service team, supervisor, auditor, and manager may each interpret the complaint differently.

## Possible perceptions

- Customer: slow service
- Supervisor: staff issue
- Auditor: process weakness
- Manager: resource constraint

## Key message

**Evidence moves the discussion from opinion to analysis.**

Quality connection: wrong interpretation can lead to wrong corrective action.

Attribution theory asks whether behavior is internally or externally caused.

## Internal attribution

Cause is assumed to come from the person: ability, effort, attitude, or intention.

## External attribution

Cause is assumed to come from the situation: process, workload, tools, system, or context.

## Three questions

Distinctiveness

Does the person behave differently in other situations?

Consensus

Do others behave the same way in this situation?

Consistency

Does the behavior repeat over time?

Teaching point: ask all three questions before judging the cause.

Small groups | 20 minutes

**Scenario: An employee submitted the monthly quality report three days late.**

## Group task

1. Check distinctiveness.
2. Check consensus.
3. Check consistency.
4. Decide whether the likely cause is internal, external, or mixed.
5. State what evidence is still needed before action.

## Deliverable

**Attribution logic**  
+  
**Evidence needed**  
+  
**Preliminary quality response**

Quality connection: do not blame the person before checking the system.

Two common errors can distort fairness and accuracy.

## Fundamental Attribution Error

The tendency to underestimate external causes and overestimate internal causes when judging others.

## Self-Serving Bias

The tendency to attribute personal success to internal factors and personal failure to external factors.

## Quality caution

**“Operator error” should not be the first and final explanation.**

Use root-cause thinking: people, process, equipment, method, environment, and measurement.

Shortcuts reduce mental effort but can reduce decision quality.

**Selective perception**  
**People see what fits expectations.**

**Halo effect**  
**One strong trait shapes the whole judgment.**

**Contrast effects**  
**Evaluation changes because of comparison with others.**

**Stereotyping**  
**Judgment is based on assumptions about a group.**

Teaching point: shortcuts may help speed, but they can distort evaluation, audit judgments, and improvement decisions.

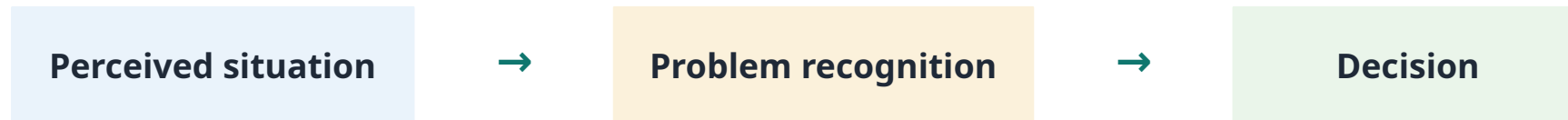
Classify the shortcut or error.

- A. "He is always late; therefore, he does not care about quality."
- B. "She communicates very well; therefore, she must be an excellent manager."
- C. "The previous audit team was excellent, so this team looks weak."
- D. "Employees from this department always resist change."

**Task: identify the likely shortcut/error and state what evidence should be checked before action.**

Quality connection: judgment quality improves when assumptions are tested.

Decision making occurs in reaction to a perceived problem.



If the problem is wrongly perceived, the decision is likely to focus on the wrong cause, wrong criteria, or wrong solution.

Quality use: a complaint can be framed as a people problem, process problem, or resource problem.

A structured route to better decisions.

## Six steps

**1. Define problem**

**2. Identify criteria**

**3. Weight criteria**

**4. Develop alternatives**

**5. Evaluate alternatives**

**6. Select best alternative**

**Quality use: a structured model reduces impulsive blame and improves corrective-action decisions.**

Example: customer complaints increased by 25% → define the problem before selecting the solution.

Real managers rarely have perfect information.

**Limited information**

**Limited time**

**Limited cognitive capacity**

## Bounded rationality

People often choose a satisfactory option rather than the mathematically optimal option.

## Intuition

An unconscious process based on accumulated experience. Useful, but still needs evidence checks.

Quality caution: experienced intuition should guide investigation, not replace evidence.

Biases affect search, interpretation, and choice.

**Overconfidence**

**Anchoring**

**Confirmation**

**Availability**

**Escalation of commitment**

**Risk aversion**

## Quality implication

**Anchoring, confirmation, and availability are common when managers jump too quickly to familiar explanations.**

Teaching point: ask what evidence would change your mind.

A quality-related judgment under uncertainty.

**“We had the same problem last year, and it was caused by staff shortage. So this must be the same reason.”**

## Discussion questions

- Which bias may be influencing the manager?
- What information is still missing?
- What alternative explanations should be considered?
- What evidence should be collected first?

**Teaching point: similarity with the past is not enough; evidence is still required.**

Individual differences and organizational constraints both matter.

## Individual differences

- Personality
- Experience
- Values
- Tolerance for ambiguity

## Organizational constraints

- Performance evaluation
- Reward systems
- Formal rules
- Time pressure
- Historical precedents

**A person may know the better decision, but the system around them shapes what they actually do.**

Robbins and Judge present three ethical lenses.

## **Utilitarianism**

**Greatest good for the greatest number.**

## **Rights**

**Protect fundamental rights and liberties.**

## **Justice**

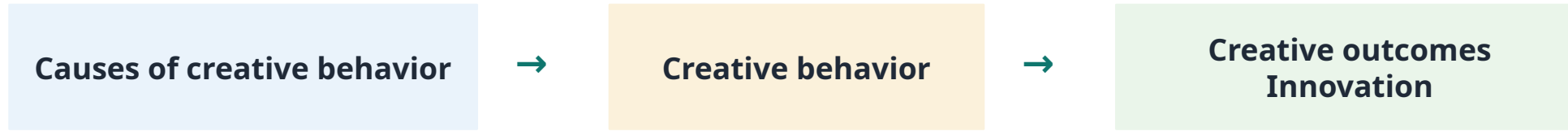
**Apply rules fairly and impartially.**

## Quality dilemma

A limited product defect is discovered before delivery. Which criterion would justify shipment, stoppage, or equal treatment of all batches?

Teaching point: ethical criteria clarify trade-offs, but they do not remove the need for evidence.

Better decisions need better alternatives.



## Quality use

**When routine responses are weak, creativity expands the alternatives available for improvement and problem solving.**

Quality connection: creativity is not decoration; it improves the alternative set for decisions.

Use the case to connect perception, attribution, bias, and decision making.

## Case

A hospital receives a customer complaint about long waiting time. The supervisor immediately blames the receptionist. Later review shows system downtime, staff shortage, and unclear appointment procedures.

## Questions

1. What attribution error is visible?
2. Which external factors were ignored?
3. Which bias may reinforce the first judgment?
4. What evidence should be collected?
5. What better decision process should be used?

Quality connection: observation → evidence → cause analysis → decision → corrective action.

End with the textbook's core implications for managers.

## Key takeaways

1. Perception shapes judgment and behavior.
2. Attribution theory helps managers separate internal and external causes.
3. Shortcuts and biases make decisions fast but risky.
4. Structured decision making improves quality responses.
5. Ethics and creativity widen the quality of choices.

## Post-class reflection

Identify one workplace or quality decision where perception or bias could lead to a wrong conclusion. Explain one evidence-based action you would use to improve the decision.

## Deadline

**Tuesday, 22 September 2026 • 11:59 PM (Makkah time)**

**Thank you**